a large posse of police personnel in riot gear ready to intervene in case of any law-and-order issue arising during the meeting.

Nair had come fully prepared. He recalls that he, along with a group of nearly 2,500 workers, had arrived by train from Pune earlier that day. He said that the police had tried to prevent them from going to the AGM venue, but he had told them that his workers had proxy letters from shareholders that entitled them to attend the meeting.

On reaching the venue, he and his men occupied nearly all the seats in the auditorium and Nair himself sat in the front row. As the hall filled with his supporters, all wearing red bandanas, many had to stand behind, along the wall. It was a scary sight—red-topped heads wherever one looked. JRD was also in attendance, seated on the raised dais along with Ratan and other senior management. No sooner had he taken his seat than he looked straight ahead into the audience and saw lines of red, broken at intervals. He turned to Ratan and said sharply, 'What is this? You haven't been able to control this? If Mody were here, this would not have happened.'

JRD's 'words were ringing in my ears all through the meeting', Ratan says. To compound his consternation, many anxious shareholders stood up and demanded that the management consider hiking the workers' wages. Some even blamed the company leadership for being insensitive to the workers' genuine demands. It was the most turbulent AGM Ratan would ever attend.

The meeting did not end peacefully either. After a while, the workers became restless and started shouting and disrupting the proceedings. Finally, the police were called in, the unruly workers removed and the AGM hastily concluded. The new chairman was a harrowed man.

Political Ambivalence

The management also came under pressure from the state political leadership. Maharashtra Chief Minister Sharad Pawar said in the state assembly on 23 March that the TELCO management should recognize Nair as the leader of the union. Less than two months later, Pawar reiterated his stance to a business newspaper, saying that 'he would not budge from his earlier stand on the TELCO labour stalemate'.

The production at the TELCO plants had dipped drastically. They were rolling out not more than seventy vehicles a day—half of their usual